Q+A

The WIND GOD

Flautist ***Hariprasad Chaurasia*** *is performing live with singer Hariharan for the first time. After a performance in Mumbai,* Living Legends: Hari Se Hari Tak—A Soulful Night of Music *is next taking place at Delhi's Siri Fort Auditorium on May 30*

Q. Your father wanted you to be a wrestler. How did you manage to become a musician?

My father wanted me to carry on the family tradition. However, my heart followed music. I developed a keen interest listening to my neighbour, Pandit Rajaram, who was a dhrupad exponent and music teacher. My mother used to sing lullabies, so maybe there were some music genes as well.

Q. How did you decide to start playing the flute?

I started taking vocal lessons from Pandit Rajaram but my vocal range wasn't what is expected from singers. So, he suggested that I choose an instrument as a medium to pursue music lessons. For my limited resources, the flute was a perfect choice and I found it accidentally. That was the turning point of my life.

Q. You have seen the music scene evolve over the decades. What is better or worse now for musicians compared to earlier?

The music scene has expanded and become more inclusive, but it lacks depth. Today, musicians can reach out to the entire world sitting in their own space. However, it saddens me to see that the patience level has come down so much. There is an urgency to perform, excel and achieve success in the minimum time. This affects their learning, riyaaz and understanding of music. Even listeners are not like the ones we had earlier, who could sit throughout the night listening to an artist.

Q. What else can fans expect from you next?

Bansuri Jab Gaane Lage is a new musical by my gurukul. It is based on my life story and music in Indian cinema. After being staged in Bengaluru recently, it is travelling to the National Centre for Performing Arts, Mumbai, on May 30.

—with Neha Kirpal

Photograph by **HARDIK CHHABRA**